SPOKEN ENGLISH

Detailed Unit-wise Notes (Units I to V)

Spoken English is the ability to use English correctly, clearly and confidently in everyday situations. It brings together **grammar** (correct structure), **vocabulary** (the right words), **pronunciation** (clear sounds, stress and intonation), **conversation** (speaking with others, alone and in groups) and **listening and body language** (receiving the message and supporting it with the whole body).

Course Learning Outcomes (CLOs)

- CLO 1: Speak English with proficiency.
- CLO 2: Demonstrate knowledge in the correct use of grammar and pronunciation.
- CLO 3: Develop an appreciation of practical ways of learning to speak simple and correct English.
- CLO 4: Use the studies undertaken in the field of spoken English in a range of practical contexts.
- CLO 5: Apply knowledge and skills in the field of spoken English to relevant contexts, thus aiding in handling everyday situations.

Units at a Glance

Unit	Title	Main topics
I	Working with Grammar	Sentence construction; types of sentences; parts of speech; auxiliary verbs; singular and plural; active and passive voice; degrees of comparison; determiners; subject-verb agreement; punctuation; common errors and usage
II	Vocabulary Building and Pronunciation	Word formation; synonyms and antonyms; homonyms; one-word substitutes; changing one part of speech to another; odd-one-out; idioms and phrases; joining sentences; vowel and consonant sounds; word stress; sentence stress; intonation; practice in pronunciation
III	Conversational Skills	Basics of conversation; describing people, places, situations and events; extempore speeches; persuasive and descriptive speeches; speaking through narration; narrating stories and describing characters
IV	Group Communication	Group discussion; assigning tasks; appointing group leaders; task completion; group cohesion; group presentations; PowerPoint presentations
V	Listening Skills and Non-verbal Communication	Importance and basics of listening; barriers; gist, style and tone; voice recording; body language; gestures, posture, eye contact, facial expressions; etiquette

How to Use These Notes

- Read one topic at a time, then practise it aloud.
- Use the examples as models and make your own sentences.
- Revise tables (tenses, plurals, idioms, one-word substitutes) regularly.
- Practise the sample dialogues and speeches with a partner.

UNIT I - WORKING WITH GRAMMAR

Grammar is the system of rules that tells us how words are formed and how they are arranged to make meaningful sentences. Without grammar, words are only a heap of sounds; with grammar, they carry clear meaning. In spoken English, correct grammar makes you easy to understand and creates a good impression. This unit explains the building blocks of English one by one.

1. Sentence Construction

A **sentence** is a group of words arranged in a proper order that expresses a complete thought. It begins with a capital letter in writing and ends with a full stop, question mark or exclamation mark. Every sentence has two essential parts:

- **Subject:** the person, place or thing the sentence is about (who or what does the action).
- **Predicate:** everything that says something about the subject; it always contains a **verb**.

In the sentence *The tall boy kicked the ball*, 'The tall boy' is the subject and 'kicked the ball' is the predicate.

Basic sentence patterns

Pattern	Example	Explanation
Subject + Verb (S+V)	Birds fly.	The verb needs nothing more (intransitive verb).
Subject + Verb + Object (S+V+O)	She reads novels.	The object receives the action (transitive verb).
Subject + Verb + Complement (S+V+C)	He became a doctor.	The complement describes or renames the subject (linking verb).
Subject + Verb + Indirect Object + Direct Object	The teacher gave us homework.	'us' receives the thing; 'homework' is what is given.
Subject + Verb + Object + Complement	They elected him leader.	The complement describes the object.
Subject + Verb + Adverbial	The meeting ends at five.	Adds time, place or manner.

Phrases and clauses

- A **phrase** is a group of words without a subject-verb pair: *in the garden, very fast, to win the race*.
- A **clause** has a subject and a verb. An **independent (main) clause** can stand alone: *I went home*. A **dependent (subordinate) clause** cannot: *because I was tired*.

Rules for building correct sentences

- Keep the usual word order: Subject - Verb - Object. Adjectives come before nouns; adverbs of frequency come before the main verb (*She always smiles*).
- Make the subject and verb agree in number and person.
- Use one tense consistently within a sentence unless the meaning changes.
- Avoid sentence fragments ('Because it rained.') and run-on sentences (two sentences joined without a conjunction or full stop).
- Place modifiers next to the word they describe: *She nearly drove 100 km* and *She drove nearly 100 km* mean different things.

2. Types of Sentences

A. Based on function (purpose)

Type	Purpose	Example	Ends with
Declarative (assertive)	States a fact, opinion or information. Can be affirmative or negative.	India is a large country. / I do not like coffee.	Full stop
Interrogative	Asks a question. Starts with a wh-word or an auxiliary verb.	Where do you live? / Is she at home?	Question mark
Imperative	Gives a command, request, advice or instruction. The subject 'you' is understood.	Open the window. / Please sit down.	Full stop or exclamation mark
Exclamatory	Expresses sudden or strong feeling. Often begins with What or How.	What a lovely view! / How brave he is!	Exclamation mark
Optative	Expresses a wish, prayer or blessing.	May you live long!	Exclamation mark

B. Based on structure

Type	Structure	Example
Simple	One independent clause (one subject-verb unit).	The sun rises in the east.
Compound	Two or more independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction (and, but, or, so, yet, for, nor).	She sang, and he played the guitar.
Complex	One independent clause + one or more dependent clauses joined by a subordinating word (because, if, when, although, who, which).	I will call you when I reach home.
Compound-complex	Two or more independent clauses + at least one dependent clause.	Although it was late, she finished her work, and he went home.

Tip for speaking: Use short simple sentences for clarity, and add compound and complex sentences to show detail and connect ideas. A good speaker mixes all four structures.

3. Parts of Speech

Every word in a sentence does a job. Based on the job, words are grouped into **eight parts of speech**: noun, pronoun, verb, adjective, adverb, preposition, conjunction and interjection. Note that the same word can be a different part of speech in different sentences: *Light* (noun) *a light* (adjective) *to light* (verb).

(a) Noun

A noun names a person, place, animal, thing, quality or idea.

Kind	Meaning	Examples
Proper noun	Particular name of a person, place or thing; begins with a capital letter	Kalam, Puducherry, Ganga, Monday
Common noun	General name of a class	boy, city, river, book
Collective noun	Name of a group taken as one	team, class, flock, committee

Kind	Meaning	Examples
Material noun	Name of a substance from which things are made	gold, wood, water, cotton
Abstract noun	Name of a quality, feeling, state or action; cannot be touched	honesty, beauty, childhood, laughter

Nouns may also be **countable** (book, books) or **uncountable** (water, advice, information).

(b) Pronoun

A pronoun is used in place of a noun to avoid repeating it: *Ravi said that **he** was tired.*

Kind	Examples	Sentence
Personal	I, you, he, she, it, we, they; me, him, her, us, them	She helped me.
Possessive	mine, yours, his, hers, ours, theirs	This pen is mine.
Reflexive / emphatic	myself, yourself, himself, themselves	He hurt himself.
Demonstrative	this, that, these, those	Those are my books.
Interrogative	who, whom, whose, which, what	Whose bag is this?
Relative	who, whom, whose, which, that	The girl who sang is my sister.
Indefinite	someone, anybody, nobody, all, few, each	Everyone was present.

(c) Verb

A verb expresses an action (run, write), a state (be, seem) or an occurrence (become). It is the heart of the sentence.

- **Transitive verbs** need an object (She *wrote* a letter); **intransitive verbs** do not (She *smiled*).
- **Linking verbs** connect the subject to a complement: be, become, seem, look, feel, appear.
- **Regular verbs** form the past with -ed (walk, walked); **irregular verbs** change form (go, went, gone; write, wrote, written).
- **Finite verbs** change with tense and subject; **non-finite** forms are the infinitive (to go), gerund (going) and participles (going, gone).
- **Stative verbs** (know, love, want, own, belong) are not normally used in continuous tenses.

The twelve tenses

Tense shows the time of an action. English has three times (present, past, future), each with four aspects.

Tense	Use	Example (verb: write)
Simple present	Habits, general truths	She writes every day.
Present continuous	Action happening now	She is writing now.
Present perfect	Past action with present result	She has written a letter.
Present perfect continuous	Action started in the past and still going on	She has been writing for an hour.
Simple past	Finished action in the past	She wrote a letter yesterday.
Past continuous	Action in progress at a past time	She was writing when I came.
Past perfect	Action completed before another past action	She had written before I came.

Tense	Use	Example (verb: write)
Past perfect continuous	Longer action up to a past moment	She had been writing for an hour.
Simple future	Decisions, predictions	She will write tomorrow.
Future continuous	Action in progress at a future time	She will be writing at 5 p.m.
Future perfect	Action completed by a future time	She will have written by Monday.
Future perfect continuous	Duration up to a future time	She will have been writing for an hour.

(d) Adjective

An adjective describes or limits a noun or pronoun. It answers: what kind? how many? which? whose?

Kind	Examples
Quality	a *brave* soldier, *cold* water
Quantity	*some* milk, *enough* food, *little* time
Number	*three* pens, *many* students, the *first* row
Demonstrative	*this* house, *those* boys
Possessive	*my* book, *their* car
Interrogative	*Which* road? *What* time?

Order of adjectives (when more than one): opinion, size, age, shape, colour, origin, material - *a lovely small old round red Indian wooden box.*

(e) Adverb

An adverb describes a verb, an adjective or another adverb. It answers: how? when? where? how often? how much?

Kind	Examples
Manner	She speaks *clearly*. He walked *slowly*.
Time	I will come *tomorrow*. They left *early*.
Place	Come *here*. He looked *around*.
Frequency	He *always* smiles. She *rarely* complains.
Degree	It is *very* cold. She is *quite* clever.

Many adverbs are formed by adding **-ly** to an adjective (quick - quickly), but some do not end in -ly (fast, well, hard, late).

(f) Preposition

A preposition shows the relation of a noun or pronoun to another word in the sentence.

- **Time:** at 5 o'clock, on Monday, in June, since 2020, for two hours, by evening.
- **Place:** at the bus stop, on the table, in the room, under the bridge, between the two houses.
- **Direction:** to the market, into the house, across the road, towards the school.
- Rule: *at* for a point (at the door, at 9 a.m.), *on* for a surface or day (on the wall, on Friday), *in* for an enclosed space or longer period (in the box, in 2025).

(g) Conjunction

A conjunction joins words, phrases or clauses.

Kind	Function	Examples
Coordinating	Joins equal parts	and, but, or, so, yet, for, nor
Subordinating	Joins a dependent clause to a main clause	because, although, if, unless, when, while, since, after, before
Correlative	Used in pairs	either...or, neither...nor, both...and, not only...but also

(h) Interjection

An interjection is a word that expresses sudden emotion and is not grammatically connected to the sentence: *Hurrah! We won. Alas! He is gone. Oh! I forgot. Wow! What a view.* It is followed by an exclamation mark or a comma.

4. Auxiliary Verbs

Auxiliary verbs (helping verbs) are used with a main verb to form tenses, questions, negatives, the passive voice, and to show ability, possibility, permission or obligation. In *She **is** singing*, 'is' is the auxiliary and 'singing' is the main verb.

Primary auxiliaries: be, have, do

Verb	Forms	Use	Example
be	am, is, are, was, were, been, being	Continuous tenses and passive voice	He is reading. The door was opened.
have	have, has, had	Perfect tenses	They have arrived.
do	do, does, did	Questions, negatives, emphasis	Do you know her? I did not go.

These three verbs can also be main verbs: *She **has** a car. They **are** students. I **do** my homework.*

Modal auxiliaries

Modals always come with the base form of a verb, have no -s in the third person and have no infinitive or -ing form.

Modal	Meaning / use	Example
can	Ability, permission (informal), possibility	I can swim. Can I go out?
could	Past ability, polite request	He could run fast. Could you help me?
may	Permission (formal), possibility	May I come in? It may rain.
might	Weaker possibility	She might be late.
shall	Future with I/we, offer or suggestion	Shall we begin?
will	Future, promise, willingness	I will help you.
should	Advice, duty	You should see a doctor.
would	Polite request, habit in the past, conditional	Would you like tea? If I were rich, I would travel.
must	Strong obligation, strong certainty	You must wear a helmet. He must be tired.

Modal	Meaning / use	Example
ought to	Moral duty, advice	We ought to respect elders.

Forming questions and negatives: Put the auxiliary before the subject for a question (*Has she finished?*) and add *not* after it for a negative (*She has not finished*). If there is no auxiliary, use *do/does/did* (*Does he play? He does not play.*).

5. Singular and Plural

Number tells whether a noun refers to one (singular) or more than one (plural). Learning plural rules prevents common errors.

Rule	Examples
Most nouns add -s	book - books, pen - pens
Nouns ending in s, x, z, ch, sh add -es	bus - buses, box - boxes, church - churches, dish - dishes
Consonant + y: change y to i and add -es	city - cities, baby - babies
Vowel + y: add -s	boy - boys, key - keys
Nouns ending in f/fe: usually change to -ves	leaf - leaves, wife - wives, knife - knives (but roof - roofs, chief - chiefs)
Nouns ending in o: some add -es, some -s	potato - potatoes, hero - heroes; photo - photos, piano - pianos
Irregular plurals	man - men, woman - women, child - children, foot - feet, tooth - teeth, mouse - mice, ox - oxen, person - people
Same form in singular and plural	sheep, deer, fish, series, species
Foreign plurals	datum - data, crisis - crises, phenomenon - phenomena, syllabus - syllabi
Compound nouns: pluralise the main word	mother-in-law - mothers-in-law, passer-by - passers-by
Always plural	scissors, trousers, spectacles, clothes, police
Uncountable (no plural)	information, advice, furniture, luggage, news, knowledge, equipment

6. Active and Passive Voice

Voice shows whether the subject does the action or receives it. In the **active voice** the subject is the doer (*The cat caught the mouse*). In the **passive voice** the subject is acted upon (*The mouse was caught by the cat*).

How to change active to passive

- Make the object of the active sentence the subject of the passive sentence.
- Use the correct form of **be** (matching the tense) followed by the **past participle (V3)** of the main verb.
- Add **by** + the original subject (the agent), if it is important.

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple present	She writes a letter.	A letter is written by her.
Present continuous	She is writing a letter.	A letter is being written by her.
Present perfect	She has written a letter.	A letter has been written by her.

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple past	She wrote a letter.	A letter was written by her.
Past continuous	She was writing a letter.	A letter was being written by her.
Past perfect	She had written a letter.	A letter had been written by her.
Simple future	She will write a letter.	A letter will be written by her.
Modal	She can write a letter.	A letter can be written by her.

Other sentence types

- **Questions:** Did he break the glass? - Was the glass broken by him?
- **Commands:** Close the door. - Let the door be closed. / You are requested to close the door.
- **Two objects:** He gave me a book. - I was given a book. / A book was given to me.

When to use the passive

- When the doer is unknown or unimportant: *My bicycle was stolen.*
- When the action or the result is more important than the doer: *The bridge was built in 1990.*
- In formal, scientific and news writing: *The samples were heated to 100 degrees.*

Note: Intransitive verbs (arrive, sleep, die) have no object and therefore cannot be made passive.

7. Degrees of Comparison

Adjectives and adverbs have three degrees that show how much of a quality something has.

- **Positive degree:** no comparison. *Ravi is tall.*
- **Comparative degree:** compares two things. *Ravi is taller than Kumar.*
- **Superlative degree:** compares one thing with all others in a group (three or more). *Ravi is the tallest boy in the class.*

Rules of formation

Rule	Positive	Comparative	Superlative
One-syllable words: add -er, -est	small	smaller	smallest
Words ending in e: add -r, -st	wise	wiser	wisest
Consonant + y: change y to i	happy	happier	happiest
Short words with one vowel + one consonant: double the consonant	big	bigger	biggest
Words of two or more syllables: use more, most	beautiful	more beautiful	most beautiful
Irregular	good / well	better	best
Irregular	bad / ill	worse	worst
Irregular	much / many	more	most
Irregular	far	farther / further	farthest / furthest
Irregular	old	older / elder	oldest / eldest

Changing degrees without changing meaning

- **Superlative to comparative:** Ravi is the tallest boy. = Ravi is taller than any other boy.

- **Superlative to positive:** Ravi is the tallest boy. = No other boy is as tall as Ravi.
- **Comparative to positive:** She is wiser than he. = He is not as wise as she.

Always use **than** after a comparative and **the** before a superlative. Do not use double comparatives or superlatives (not 'more better', 'most easiest').

8. Determiners

A determiner is a word placed before a noun to make clear which person or thing is meant, or how many or how much. A noun phrase usually needs a determiner: we say *the book*, *my book* or *some books*, not just *book* (for a singular countable noun).

Kind	Words	Examples
Articles	a, an, the	a pen, an apple, the sun
Demonstratives	this, that, these, those	this book, those boys
Possessives	my, your, his, her, its, our, their	our school
Quantifiers	some, any, much, many, few, a few, little, a little, enough, all, most	many students, little water
Numerals	one, two, first, second	two cups, the third day
Distributives	each, every, either, neither, both	each child, every day
Interrogative	which, what, whose	Which bus? Whose pen?

Using articles correctly

- **a** goes before a consonant *sound*: a book, a university (starts with a 'yoo' sound), a one-rupee coin.
- **an** goes before a vowel *sound*: an apple, an hour (silent h), an MBA.
- **the** is used for something specific or already mentioned, unique things (the sun, the moon), rivers, seas, mountain ranges, and superlatives (the best).
- **No article** is used with plural or uncountable nouns in a general sense (Books are useful; Honesty is the best policy), names of people, most countries and meals.
- **few / little** have a negative sense (hardly any); **a few / a little** have a positive sense (some). 'He has few friends' = he is lonely. 'He has a few friends' = he has some.

Much / many / few / little: use *many* and *few* with countable nouns; use *much* and *little* with uncountable nouns.

9. Subject-Verb Agreement

The verb must agree with its subject in **number** (singular or plural) and **person**. Singular subjects take singular verbs (the third-person singular present adds -s/-es) and plural subjects take plural verbs.

Rule	Example
1. A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb.	The boy plays. The boys play.
2. Two or more subjects joined by *and* take a plural verb.	Ravi and Kumar are friends.
3. But if the two joined subjects mean one thing, the verb is singular.	Bread and butter is my breakfast.
4. With *or, nor, either...or, neither...nor*, the verb agrees with the subject nearer to it.	Neither the teacher nor the students were present.

Rule	Example
5. Words between the subject and the verb do not change the verb.	The box of apples is heavy.
6. Each, every, either, neither, one, everyone, someone, nobody take a singular verb.	Everyone is here. Each of the girls has a book.
7. Collective nouns take a singular verb when the group acts as one, a plural verb when members act separately.	The team has won. The team are arguing among themselves.
8. Subjects joined by *with, along with, together with, as well as* do not change the verb.	The teacher, along with her students, is going.
9. Plural-looking subjects that are singular in meaning take singular verbs (news, mathematics, physics, measles).	The news is good. Mathematics is difficult.
10. Expressions of money, time and distance as a whole amount take a singular verb.	Ten kilometres is a long walk.
11. A number as a unit takes a singular verb; the number of takes singular, a number of takes plural.	The number of students is 40. A number of students are absent.
12. In *there is / there are*, the verb agrees with the noun that follows.	There are five books on the desk.

10. Punctuation

Punctuation marks are symbols that show the pauses, stops and tone of written language. They make meaning clear: *Let's eat, Grandma!* and *Let's eat Grandma!* mean very different things.

Mark	Uses	Examples
Full stop (.)	Ends a statement or command; used in abbreviations.	I live in Puducherry. / Dr. Rao
Comma (,)	Separates items in a list; separates an introductory word or clause; sets off extra information; used before conjunctions joining two clauses; after yes/no and in direct address.	I bought rice, dal, and oil. / However, he agreed. / Ravi, come here.
Question mark (?)	Ends a direct question (not an indirect question).	What is your name? / He asked what my name was.
Exclamation mark (!)	Shows strong feeling, surprise or a command.	What a surprise!
Colon (:)	Introduces a list, explanation or quotation; separates hours and minutes.	You need three things: a pen, a book, and a bag.
Semicolon (;)	Joins two closely related independent clauses; separates complex list items.	She was tired; she went to sleep.
Apostrophe (')	Shows possession and contractions.	Ravi's book; the girls' room; don't; it's (it is). Its = possessive: The dog wagged its tail.
Quotation marks (" ")	Enclose the exact words spoken, titles of short works.	He said, "I will come."
Hyphen (-)	Joins parts of compound words; splits words at line end.	well-known, mother-in-law, twenty-one

Mark	Uses	Examples
Dash (-)	Shows a sudden break or adds emphasis.	He had one fear - failure.
Brackets ( )	Enclose extra information.	Mumbai (formerly Bombay) is large.
Capital letters	First word of a sentence, proper nouns, I, days, months, titles.	Monday, Chennai, Dr. Kalam

11. Common Errors and Usage

Learners often repeat certain mistakes. Knowing them helps you check your own speech and writing.

Category	Wrong	Correct
Agreement	He don't know the answer.	He doesn't know the answer.
Agreement	Each of the boys have a pen.	Each of the boys has a pen.
Tense	I have seen him yesterday.	I saw him yesterday.
Tense	I am knowing him.	I know him.
Tense	She is living here since 2020.	She has been living here since 2020.
Comparison	She is more taller than me.	She is taller than me.
Comparison	This is the most best book.	This is the best book.
Articles	He is an European.	He is a European.
Articles	She is the best of the all.	She is the best of all.
Uncountable nouns	He gave me many advices.	He gave me much advice.
Uncountable nouns	The furnitures are new.	The furniture is new.
Countable / uncountable	Less students came.	Fewer students came.
Prepositions	I am good in English.	I am good at English.
Prepositions	He is married with a doctor.	He is married to a doctor.
Prepositions	She is angry on me.	She is angry with me.
Gerund after 'to'	I look forward to meet you.	I look forward to meeting you.
Pronouns	Me and him went there.	He and I went there.
Pronouns	Between you and I.	Between you and me.
Word order	He asked me where was I going.	He asked me where I was going.
Double negative	I don't know nothing.	I don't know anything.
Confused words	I will lose my way. (lose / loose)	I do not want to lose it. The knot is loose.
Confused words	Their going home. (their / they're)	They're going home.

Strategy: Check each sentence for (1) subject-verb agreement, (2) correct tense, (3) correct preposition, (4) correct article, and (5) correct word form. Read the corrected sentence aloud so the right form becomes natural.

UNIT II - VOCABULARY BUILDING AND PRONUNCIATION

Vocabulary is the stock of words you know and use. A wide vocabulary lets you express exact meanings, understand what you hear and read, and sound confident. **Pronunciation** is how you say those words. Good speech needs both: the right word, said the right way.

1. Word Formation

New words are made from existing words by several processes. Knowing them lets you work out the meaning of unfamiliar words.

(a) Affixation: prefixes and suffixes

An **affix** is a group of letters added to a base (root) word. A **prefix** comes before it and usually changes the meaning; a **suffix** comes after it and usually changes the part of speech.

Prefix	Meaning	Examples
un-, in-, im-, il-, ir-, non-	not	unhappy, incorrect, impossible, illegal, irregular, nonsense
dis-, mis-	opposite, wrongly	disagree, dislike, misunderstand, misuse
re-	again	rewrite, rebuild, return
pre-	before	preview, prepare, prehistoric
post-	after	postpone, postgraduate
sub-	under	submarine, subway
inter-	between	international, interval
anti-	against	antibiotic, anti-social
over-, under-	too much, too little	overeat, underestimate
bi-, tri-, multi-	two, three, many	bicycle, triangle, multinational

Suffix	Makes	Examples
-ness, -ment, -tion, -sion, -ity, -ship, -hood, -ance, -ence	nouns	kindness, achievement, creation, decision, ability, friendship, childhood, importance
-er, -or, -ist, -ian	person who does	teacher, actor, artist, musician
-ful, -ous, -ive, -al, -ic, -able, -ible, -less, -y	adjectives	careful, famous, active, national, heroic, readable, careless, rainy
-ly	adverbs	quickly, happily
-ize / -ise, -en, -ify	verbs	modernize, strengthen, simplify

(b) Other methods

- **Compounding:** two words joined: sun + flower = sunflower; black + board = blackboard; mother-in-law.
- **Conversion:** a word changes its part of speech without changing form: a *drink* (noun) - to *drink* (verb).
- **Blending:** parts of two words: breakfast + lunch = brunch; smoke + fog = smog; motor + hotel = motel.
- **Clipping:** shortening: examination - exam; telephone - phone; influenza - flu.

- **Acronyms:** initial letters pronounced as a word: NASA, UNESCO, laser, radar.
- **Borrowing:** words taken from other languages: bungalow, shampoo, jungle (Indian languages); restaurant (French).

2. Synonyms and Antonyms

Synonyms

Synonyms are words with the same or nearly the same meaning. No two synonyms are exactly alike: they may differ in formality, strength or usage. *Begin* and *commence* mean the same, but *commence* is more formal. Using synonyms avoids repetition and makes speech richer.

Word	Synonyms	Word	Synonyms
Brave	courageous, bold, fearless	Happy	joyful, cheerful, glad
Rapid	quick, fast, swift	Big	large, huge, enormous
Ancient	old, antique, archaic	Smart	clever, intelligent, bright
Generous	liberal, kind, charitable	Begin	start, commence, initiate
Permit	allow, let, authorise	Help	assist, aid, support
Victory	triumph, success, win	Tired	exhausted, weary, fatigued
Create	make, build, produce	Angry	furious, irate, annoyed

Antonyms

Antonyms are words with opposite meanings. They are of three kinds:

- **Gradable:** hot - cold (with levels in between, like warm and cool).
- **Complementary:** alive - dead, true - false (one excludes the other).
- **Relational:** buy - sell, teacher - student, parent - child.

Word	Antonym	Word	Antonym
Brave	cowardly	Increase	decrease
Rapid	slow	Accept	reject
Ancient	modern	Success	failure
Generous	stingy, selfish	Victory	defeat
Permit	forbid, prohibit	Create	destroy
Honest	dishonest	Arrive	depart
Strong	weak	Knowledge	ignorance

Making antonyms with prefixes: happy - unhappy, possible - impossible, legal - illegal, regular - irregular, agree - disagree, honest - dishonest. Not all words follow this rule (the opposite of 'good' is 'bad', not 'ungood'), so learn them as pairs.

3. Homonyms

Homonyms are words that are the same in sound, in spelling, or in both, but different in meaning. The group includes **homophones**, **homographs** and **homonyms proper**.

(a) Homophones: same sound, different spelling and meaning

Words	Meanings
to / too / two	towards / also, excessively / the number 2
there / their / they're	in that place / belonging to them / they are
write / right / rite	put words on paper / correct, opposite of left / ceremony
piece / peace	a part / calm, freedom from war
principal / principle	head of a school, main / a rule or belief
site / sight / cite	a place / ability to see / to quote
wear / where	to put on clothes / in which place
weak / week	not strong / seven days
knew / new	past of know / not old
break / brake	to damage / a stopping device
hear / here	listen with ears / in this place
stationary / stationery	not moving / writing materials

(b) Homographs: same spelling, different meaning (and sometimes sound)

Word	Meaning 1	Meaning 2
bear	an animal	to carry or tolerate
bat	a flying animal	an instrument used in cricket
lead (led)	to guide	(led) a metal
tear (tair)	to rip	(teer) a drop from the eye
row	a line of things	a quarrel
bank	a financial institution	the side of a river
light	not heavy	brightness

(c) Homonyms proper: same sound and same spelling, different meaning

Bark (the sound of a dog / the covering of a tree); *left* (opposite of right / past of leave); *watch* (to look at / a wristwatch); *ring* (a circle of metal worn on a finger / to sound a bell).

Tip: Use each pair in a sentence to remember it: *I want to go there to see their house, but they're away.*

4. One-Word Substitutes

One word can replace a whole phrase or clause. This makes speech and writing crisp and is a very common test item.

Phrase	One word
A person who writes his own life story	Autobiographer (the book: autobiography)
A person who loves books	Bibliophile
One who does not believe in God	Atheist
One who believes in God	Theist
One who hates mankind	Misanthrope

Phrase	One word
One who is always hopeful	Optimist
One who always sees the dark side	Pessimist
A child whose parents are dead	Orphan
A man whose wife has died	Widower
One who walks on foot	Pedestrian
One who eats both plants and meat	Omnivore
One who eats only plants	Herbivore
One who eats human flesh	Cannibal
One who speaks many languages	Polyglot
One who cannot read or write	Illiterate
That which cannot be read (handwriting)	Illegible
That which cannot be believed	Incredible
That which cannot be avoided	Inevitable
That which is present everywhere	Omnipresent
One who knows everything	Omniscient
Government by the people	Democracy
Government by one person with total power	Dictatorship / Autocracy
A place where birds are kept	Aviary
A place where books are kept	Library
A place where animals are kept for show	Zoo
Fear of open spaces	Agoraphobia
Fear of closed spaces	Claustrophobia
Study of birds	Ornithology
A speech delivered without preparation	Extempore
A medicine that kills germs	Antiseptic
A person who is new to a task or field	Novice
A person who is expert at judging art or food	Connoisseur

5. Changing One Part of Speech to Another

Many English words have related forms in different parts of speech. Changing the form helps you use the right word in the right place. Use suffixes and small spelling changes.

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
beauty	beautify	beautiful	beautifully
success	succeed	successful	successfully
decision	decide	decisive	decisively
strength	strengthen	strong	strongly

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
pleasure	please	pleasant	pleasantly
knowledge	know	knowledgeable	knowledgeably
difference	differ	different	differently
care	care	careful	carefully
danger	endanger	dangerous	dangerously
choice	choose	choosy	-
growth	grow	grown	-
energy	energise	energetic	energetically

Examples in sentences

1. He is a **success** (noun). He wants to **succeed** (verb). He is a **successful** man (adjective). He did the work **successfully** (adverb).
2. Her **kindness** (noun) shows that she is **kind** (adjective) and acts **kindly** (adverb).

6. Odd-One-Out

In an odd-one-out exercise, you find the word that does not belong to a group. To solve it:

- Find what the other words have in common (meaning, category, part of speech, spelling pattern or sound).
- Check whether the group is about synonyms, categories (fruits, cities), parts of speech or spelling/sound.
- The word that breaks the pattern is the odd one.

Examples

1. Apple, mango, carrot, banana - **carrot** (a vegetable; others are fruits).
2. Happy, joyful, cheerful, sad - **sad** (others are synonyms).
3. Run, jump, walk, table - **table** (a noun; others are verbs).
4. Chennai, Madurai, Delhi, Coimbatore - **Delhi** (not in Tamil Nadu).
5. Quick, rapid, swift, slow - **slow** (an antonym of the rest).
6. Cut, hut, nut, put - **put** (pronounced with a different vowel sound).

7. Idioms and Phrases

An **idiom** is a fixed expression whose meaning is different from the meaning of its separate words. You cannot understand *kick the bucket* (to die) by looking at 'kick' and 'bucket'. A **phrase** here means a fixed group of words, such as a phrasal verb. Idioms make speech lively and natural, but they should not be changed or translated word for word.

Idiom	Meaning	Example
A piece of cake	Very easy	The test was a piece of cake.
Break the ice	Start a conversation in an awkward situation	He told a joke to break the ice.
Once in a blue moon	Very rarely	We meet once in a blue moon.

Idiom	Meaning	Example
Spill the beans	Reveal a secret	Don't spill the beans about the party.
Hit the nail on the head	Say or do exactly the right thing	You hit the nail on the head.
Burn the midnight oil	Work late at night	She burnt the midnight oil before exams.
Under the weather	Slightly unwell	I am feeling under the weather.
Cost an arm and a leg	Very expensive	That phone cost an arm and a leg.
Let the cat out of the bag	Reveal a secret by mistake	He let the cat out of the bag.
Bite the bullet	Face a difficult situation bravely	I had to bite the bullet and ask for help.
Call it a day	Stop working for the day	It's late; let's call it a day.
Cry over spilt milk	Worry about something that cannot be changed	It is useless to cry over spilt milk.
Face the music	Accept punishment or consequences	He had to face the music.
In hot water	In trouble	He is in hot water with his boss.
On cloud nine	Extremely happy	She was on cloud nine after the result.
The ball is in your court	It is your turn to decide	I have made my offer; the ball is in your court.
Beat around the bush	Avoid the main point	Don't beat around the bush; tell me.
Add fuel to the fire	Make a bad situation worse	His remark added fuel to the fire.

Phrasal verbs

A phrasal verb is a verb + particle (preposition or adverb) with a special meaning:

Phrasal verb	Meaning	Example
give up	stop trying	Never give up.
look after	take care of	She looks after her grandmother.
look forward to	wait eagerly for	I look forward to the trip.
put off	postpone	They put off the meeting.
turn down	refuse	He turned down the offer.
carry on	continue	Carry on with your work.
break down	stop working	The car broke down.
run out of	have none left	We ran out of milk.

8. Joining Sentences

Joining short sentences into longer ones removes choppiness and shows how ideas are related. There are four main methods.

(a) Using coordinating conjunctions (and, but, or, so, yet)

It was raining. We went out. - It was raining, but we went out.

(b) Using subordinating conjunctions (because, although, if, when, while, since, unless)

- *He was tired. He kept working. - Although he was tired, he kept working.*
- *The road was blocked. We were late. - We were late because the road was blocked.*

(c) Using relative pronouns (who, whom, which, that, whose)

- *I met a man. He teaches music. - I met a man who teaches music.*
- *This is the book. I bought it yesterday. - This is the book that I bought yesterday.*

(d) Using participles, infinitives and phrases

- **Present participle:** *She opened the door. She walked in. - Opening the door, she walked in.*
- **Past participle:** *He was tired by the work. He fell asleep. - Tired by the work, he fell asleep.*
- **Infinitive:** *He went to the market. He wanted to buy fruit. - He went to the market to buy fruit.*
- **too ... to / so ... that:** *He is too weak to walk. = He is so weak that he cannot walk.*
- **Appositive:** *Kalam was a scientist. He became President. - Kalam, a scientist, became President.*

Remember: Choose the connector that matches the relation: addition (and), contrast (but, although), reason (because), result (so), condition (if), time (when, after).

9. Vowel and Consonant Sounds

English has **26 letters** but about **44 sounds** in standard British pronunciation (Received Pronunciation). Spelling is not a reliable guide: the letters 'ough' are pronounced differently in *though, through, tough, cough*. Sounds are shown in the dictionary using the **International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA)** between slanted lines.

Vowel sounds: 20 in all (12 pure vowels + 8 diphthongs)

A vowel sound is made with the air passing freely through the mouth without blocking. The position of the tongue and the shape of the lips decide the sound.

Pure vowel	Example	Pure vowel	Example
/iː/	see, team, key	/ɪ/	sit, big
/e/	bed, many	/æ/	cat, black
/ɑː/	car, father	/ɒ/	hot, dog
/ɔː/	saw, door	/ʊ/	put, book
/uː/	food, blue	/ʌ/	cup, love
/ɜː/	bird, turn	/ə/	about, teacher (the weak 'schwa')

Long vowels (marked with the length sign) are held longer than short ones: *sheep* /ʃiːp/ and *ship* /ʃɪp/ are different words.

Diphthong	Example	Diphthong	Example
/eɪ/	day, make	/aɪ/	high, my
/ɔɪ/	boy, coin	/əʊ/	go, home
/aʊ/	now, house	/ɪə/	here, ear
/eə/	hair, care	/ʊə/	tour, pure

A **diphthong** is a glide: the voice begins at one vowel and moves smoothly towards another within one syllable.

Consonant sounds: 24 in all

A consonant sound is made when the air is partly or fully blocked by the tongue, teeth or lips. Consonants are described by **voicing** (do the vocal cords vibrate?), **place** (where) and **manner** (how).

Group	Voiceless	Voiced
Plosives (air stopped, then released)	/p/ pen, /t/ tea, /k/ cat	/b/ bad, /d/ dog, /g/ go
Fricatives (air rubs through a narrow gap)	/f/ fan, /θ/ think, /s/ sun, /ʃ/ she, /h/ hat	/v/ van, /ð/ this, /z/ zoo, /ʒ/ vision
Affricates (plosive + fricative)	/tʃ/ chair	/dʒ/ judge
Nasals (air through the nose)	-	/m/ man, /n/ no, /ŋ/ sing
Approximants (liquids and glides)	-	/l/ light, /r/ red, /w/ we, /j/ yes

Common difficulties for Indian learners

- **/θ/ and /ð/** (think, this) are often said as t or d. Place the tongue lightly between the teeth and let air flow.
- **/v/ and /w/:** *vine* and *wine* are different. For /v/, the upper teeth touch the lower lip; for /w/, only the lips are rounded.
- **/p, t, k/** are aspirated (a small puff of air) at the start of a stressed syllable in English: *pen*, *tea*, *cat*.
- Do not add a vowel before consonant clusters: say *school*, not 'iskool'; *station*, not 'istation'.
- Silent letters: k in *knife*, b in *doubt*, w in *write*, l in *half*, h in *hour*.

10. Word Stress

A **syllable** is a unit of sound with one vowel sound (*to-day* has 2; *com-pu-ter* has 3). In any English word of more than one syllable, one syllable is **stressed**: it is said louder, longer and with a higher pitch. The others are weaker. Wrong stress can make a word hard to understand even when each sound is correct. In dictionaries, stress is marked before the stressed syllable.

Rule	Examples (stressed syllable in capitals)
Most two-syllable nouns and adjectives: stress on the first syllable	TAble, TEAcher, HAPpy, CLEver
Most two-syllable verbs: stress on the second syllable	deCIDE, beGIN, reLAX, preSENT (verb)
Words ending in -tion, -sion, -ic, -ical, -ity, -ify, -graphy: stress on the syllable just before the ending	eduCAtion, eCOnomic, poliTIcal, caPAcity, phoTOgraphy
Compound nouns: stress on the first part	BLACKboard, GREENhouse
Compound adjectives and verbs: stress on the second part	bad-TEMpered, underSTAND
Stress can change a noun to a verb	REcord (noun) - reCORD (verb); PREsent - preSENT; OBject - obJECT
Words with prefixes: stress usually stays on the root	unHAPpy, reTURN

Practice: Look up ten new words every week in a dictionary with audio, note the stress, and say them aloud.

11. Sentence Stress

In a sentence, not all words are equally important. **Content words** carry the meaning and are stressed: nouns, main verbs, adjectives, adverbs, negatives and question words. **Function words** are the grammar words and are usually unstressed and quick: articles, prepositions, auxiliaries, pronouns and conjunctions. This gives English its rhythm: stressed syllables come at roughly regular intervals, and the weak words are squeezed between them.

Example
Normal stress: I want to BUY a NEW BOOK from the SHOP.
Weak forms: 'to' is said /tə/, 'a' is said /ə/, 'from' is said /frəm/.

You can also stress a particular word to change the meaning (**emphatic stress**):

Sentence with emphasis	Meaning
I did not take your pen.	Someone else took it.
I did not **take** your pen.	I only borrowed it or saw it.
I did not take **your** pen.	I took someone else's pen.
I did not take your **pen**.	I took something else of yours.

12. Intonation

Intonation is the rise and fall of the voice (pitch) across a phrase or sentence. It is the 'music' of speech. It tells the listener whether you are asking or telling, whether you are sure or doubtful, and what your attitude is: happy, angry, polite or bored. The same words said with different intonation can have different meanings.

Pattern	When it is used	Example
Falling (voice goes down at the end)	Statements, commands, wh-questions (what, where, why), and to show certainty	I live in PuduCHERry. (falls) / Where do you LIVE? (falls)
Rising (voice goes up at the end)	Yes/no questions, polite requests, showing surprise or doubt	Are you COMing? (rises) / Really? (rises)
Fall-rise	Hesitation, reservation, polite correction	Well, I SUPpose so... (it may not be good)
Rising in lists	Items in a list rise; the final item falls	I bought apples (up), oranges (up), and BAnanas (down).
Tag questions	Rising if you are really asking; falling if you expect agreement	It's cold, isn't it? (falling = I expect you agree)

Tip: A flat voice with no intonation sounds bored. Use a wider pitch range when you want to sound interested and friendly.

13. Practice in Pronunciation

- **Listen and repeat:** imitate clear speakers in news bulletins, podcasts and audio dictionaries. Repeat short phrases aloud.
- **Use a good dictionary:** check IPA, stress and audio for every new word.
- **Minimal pairs:** practise words that differ by only one sound: ship / sheep, bit / beat, pull / pool, think / sink, vine / wine, bad / bed.

- **Tongue twisters:** 'She sells sea shells on the sea shore.' / 'Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled peppers.' Start slowly and increase speed.
- **Record and compare:** record yourself reading a paragraph, then compare with a model speaker and correct the differences.
- **Read aloud daily** for 10 minutes, watching stress and intonation.
- **Slow down:** clear speech is better than fast speech.
- **Mirror practice:** watch the movement of your lips and tongue.

UNIT III - CONVERSATIONAL SKILLS

Conversation is a two-way exchange of ideas, information and feelings. Good conversational skill is built on correct language, clear pronunciation, polite manners, active listening and confidence. This unit moves from everyday conversation to prepared and unprepared speeches.

1. Basics of Conversation

(a) Greetings

A greeting opens a conversation and sets the tone. Choose it according to the time, the person and the situation.

Situation	Expressions	Reply
Formal, morning/afternoon/evening	Good morning / Good afternoon / Good evening, Sir.	Good morning. How are you?
Informal	Hi! / Hello! / Hey, how's it going?	Hi! I'm fine, thanks. And you?
First meeting	How do you do? / Pleased to meet you.	How do you do? / Pleased to meet you too.
Meeting after a long time	It's so good to see you again!	Lovely to see you too!
Parting	Goodbye. / See you later. / Take care.	Bye! See you soon.
Festivals and occasions	Happy Pongal! / Congratulations! / Best wishes!	Thank you. Same to you.

(b) Introductions

- **Introducing yourself:** state your name, where you are from, what you do or study, and one interesting detail. *Hello, I am Ravi. I am from Puducherry. I am studying BCA, and I enjoy photography.*
- **Introducing others:** Say the name of the person you are introducing to the other person, and a short detail. In formal situations, mention the elder or senior person first: *Sir, may I introduce my friend Kumar? Kumar, this is Professor Rao.*
- **Responses:** *Nice to meet you. / Pleased to meet you. / I have heard a lot about you.*
- Smile, make eye contact and give a firm handshake (or a polite namaste) in formal introductions.

(c) Asking questions

There are two main types of questions:

- **Yes/no questions** begin with an auxiliary verb and are answered with yes or no: *Do you like music? Have you finished?*
- **Wh-questions** begin with what, where, when, who, whom, whose, why, which, how and ask for information: *Where do you work? How long have you lived here?*
- **Open questions** invite longer answers (*What do you think about online classes?*); **closed questions** get short answers.
- **Polite forms:** *Could you tell me the way to the library? Would you mind closing the window? Excuse me, may I ask something?*
- **Question tags:** *It's a nice day, isn't it? You don't smoke, do you?*

(d) Keeping a conversation going

- Answer fully and add a little more information, then ask a question back.
- Use small responses to show interest: *Really? I see. That's interesting. Is that so?*

- Take turns; do not dominate or interrupt.
- Choose safe, common topics: weather, studies, hobbies, food, travel, festivals.
- To close politely: *It was nice talking to you. I must go now. See you soon.*

Sample dialogue: meeting a new classmate

Priya: Good morning! I don't think we have met. I am Priya.

Arun: Good morning, Priya. I am Arun. Are you new here?

Priya: Yes, I joined the college last week. Which department are you in?

Arun: I am in Computer Applications. And you?

Priya: I am in the same department! Could you tell me where the computer lab is?

Arun: Of course. It is on the second floor. I'll show you.

Priya: Thank you so much. That's very kind of you.

Arun: You're welcome. Nice meeting you. See you in class!

Sample dialogue: asking for directions

Tourist: Excuse me, could you tell me how to get to the railway station?

Local: Certainly. Go straight for two hundred metres, turn left at the signal, and you will see it on your right.

Tourist: Is it far from here?

Local: No, it is only a five-minute walk.

Tourist: Thank you very much.

2. Describing People, Places, Situations and Events

Description paints a picture in words. To describe well, observe carefully, choose exact words and organise your points in a logical order.

Describing people

- **Physical features:** age, height, build, face, hair, dress.
- **Personality:** kind, honest, shy, cheerful, stubborn, humorous.
- **Habits and actions:** what the person usually does or says.
- **Your feeling:** why the person is special to you.

Sample

My grandmother is a short, slim woman in her seventies with silver hair and a warm smile. She wears a simple cotton sari and always smells of jasmine. She is kind and patient, and she wakes up before sunrise to prepare breakfast for everyone. Her stories are the best part of my evenings. I admire her strength and her love for the family.

Describing places

- Say where it is and how big it is.
- Describe what you see, hear, smell and feel.
- Move in order: near to far, outside to inside, or left to right.
- End with the overall impression.

Sample

Our village lies beside a quiet river, surrounded by green paddy fields. In the morning, the air is cool and filled with birdsong. At the centre stands an old banyan tree where elders gather in the evenings. It is a peaceful place, and I always feel relaxed when I return.

Describing situations and events

- Answer the questions: what happened, when, where, who was involved and why.
- Use time connectors: first, then, after that, meanwhile, finally.
- Use the past tense for events that are over, and the present tense for what is happening now.
- Add feelings and reactions to make it lively.

Sample: describing an event

Last Sunday, our college held its annual sports day. First, the Chief Guest hoisted the flag, and the students marched past. Then the races began; the crowd cheered loudly for every runner. Finally, prizes were given, and everyone went home tired but happy.

3. Extempore Speeches

An **extempore speech** is a speech given on the spot, with little or no preparation, usually after a minute or two of thinking time. It tests quick thinking, vocabulary, confidence and organisation.

How to prepare in a short time

- **Understand the topic** and decide your angle in the first few seconds.
- **Choose three points** you can speak about, and note one example for each.
- **Plan the structure:** Opening (1 sentence) - Body (3 points) - Closing (1-2 sentences).
- **Start confidently** with a question, quote or fact.
- **Speak slowly**; pauses give you time to think and make you sound confident.
- If you lose the thread, return to your plan or summarise what you have said.
- Avoid fillers (umm, uh, you know) and avoid apologising.

Sample extempore: 'Importance of Time'

Opening: 'Time and tide wait for no man' - this old saying reminds us how precious time is.

Point 1: Time is limited; once lost it never returns. A student who wastes a year cannot get it back.

Point 2: Good use of time brings success. Those who plan their day achieve more.

Point 3: Punctuality earns respect in college, at work and in life.

Closing: So let us value every minute and make each day count. Thank you.

4. Persuasive and Descriptive Speeches

Persuasive speech

A persuasive speech tries to convince the audience to accept an idea or take an action. It uses facts, logic and emotion.

- **Structure:** Attention-getter - Statement of the problem - Solution - Evidence and examples - Call to action.
- **Techniques:** rhetorical questions, statistics, short stories, repetition, and a strong, confident tone.
- **Appeals:** *logic* (facts and reasons), *emotion* (feelings and values) and *credibility* (why they should trust you).
- Address the audience's possible objections politely.

Sample persuasive opening and close: 'Say no to plastic'

Opening: 'Every minute, a truck full of plastic ends up in our seas. Can we call ourselves responsible if we let this continue?'

Close: 'The change starts with one bag. Carry a cloth bag from tomorrow. Together we can keep our earth clean.'

Descriptive speech

A descriptive speech helps the audience see, hear, smell, taste and feel a person, place, object or experience. It uses vivid details and sensory language and does not try to persuade.

- **Structure:** Introduction (what you will describe) - Body (details in a logical order) - Conclusion (overall impression or meaning).
- Use specific adjectives, comparisons (similes: 'as calm as a lake') and the five senses.

	Persuasive	Descriptive
Purpose	To convince and move to action	To create a clear picture
Language	Strong, emotional, logical	Sensory, vivid, detailed
Main tool	Reasons, evidence, call to action	Imagery and sensory detail
Example topics	Why we should plant trees	My favourite place in the monsoon

5. Speaking Through Narration

Narration is telling a story or an account of events in an order. It may be a personal experience, a news report or an imagined story.

- **Setting:** time and place of the events. **Characters:** the people (or animals) involved.
- **Plot:** the sequence: beginning (introduction) - middle (problem, rising action and climax) - end (resolution).
- **Tense:** mostly past tense; use time words such as one day, suddenly, meanwhile, at last.
- **Voice:** vary pace, pitch and volume; slow down at suspense, raise the pitch for surprise.
- **Point of view:** first person (I) or third person (he/she).

Sample narration: a personal experience

Last year, I missed my train to Chennai by two minutes. I was upset, but a kind stranger told me about a bus that left from the same station. I ran to catch it and reached my destination only half an hour late. That day I learnt that every problem has a solution if we stay calm.

6. Narrating Stories and Describing Characters and Situations of the Story

Narrating a story

- Start with a hook that catches attention: 'It was a dark, stormy night when the strange knock came.'
- Introduce the setting and main characters briefly.
- Present the problem or conflict, build tension and reach the turning point (climax).
- Conclude with the outcome and, if suitable, the moral.
- Keep to the order of events, and do not give unnecessary details.

Describing characters in a story

- Give appearance, speech, behaviour and feelings.

- 'Show' the quality through action: instead of saying 'He was generous', say 'He gave his only coat to the beggar'.
- Mention how the character changes during the story.

Describing the situation

- Explain what problem or choice the character faces, and why it matters.
- Explain the cause and the effect of the situation.

Sample: a short story told in speech

The Honest Woodcutter. A poor woodcutter was cutting wood beside a river when his iron axe fell into the water. He sat down and wept. A river spirit appeared and brought him a golden axe, but he said, 'That is not mine.' It brought a silver one; again he refused. At last it showed him his iron axe, and he said, 'This is mine.' Pleased with his honesty, the spirit gave him all three axes. **Moral:** Honesty is the best policy.

UNIT IV - GROUP COMMUNICATION

Most work in college and in jobs is done in groups. **Group communication** means exchanging ideas, information and feelings among three or more people to reach a common goal. It needs speaking, listening, cooperation and leadership.

1. Basics of Group Discussion

A **group discussion (GD)** is a structured, spoken exchange of views among a small group (usually 8 to 12 people) on a given topic. There is no winner or loser: the aim is to examine the topic from many angles and, if possible, reach a common conclusion. GDs are used in college activities, admissions and job selection because they show knowledge, communication, teamwork, leadership and attitude.

Stages of a group discussion

Stage	What happens	Useful expressions
Initiation	Someone starts with a definition, a fact, a quotation or a question on the topic. A good start shows confidence, but a rushed or poor start can hurt.	'Let me begin by defining...' / 'Statistics show that...'
Body	Members present points with reasons and examples, respond to others, agree or disagree politely, and move the discussion forward.	'I agree with Ravi that...' / 'I see it differently because...' / 'To add to that...'
Summary / conclusion	A member sums up the main points and the group's view, without adding new ideas.	'To sum up, the group felt that...'

Types of GD topics

- **Factual:** 'India's space programme.'
- **Controversial:** 'Should homework be banned?' - present balanced points.
- **Abstract:** 'Blue is better than red.'
- **Case-based:** a situation is given and the group must find a solution.

Do's and don'ts

Do	Do not
Listen carefully to others before speaking	Interrupt or speak over others
Support your points with facts and examples	Make statements without reasons
Speak clearly, politely and at a moderate speed	Shout, argue or lose your temper
Invite quiet members: 'What do you think, Meena?'	Dominate the discussion or stay completely silent
Stay on the topic; use inclusive words like 'we' and 'our view'	Go off topic or make personal remarks
Keep eye contact with all members; use positive body language	Look only at the leader or the floor
Disagree politely: 'I respect your point, but...'	Say 'You are wrong'

Sample GD: 'Social media: boon or bane?' (extract)

A: Good morning, everyone. Let me begin by saying that social media connects billions of people, but it also brings serious risks. Let us look at both sides.

B: I agree with A. On the positive side, students use it to learn, share notes and find jobs.

C: That is true. But I see the other side too: excessive use leads to addiction and waste of time.

D: To add to C's point, false news spreads quickly. We need to be careful about what we share.

A: To sum up, the group felt that social media is useful if used wisely and with limits.

2. Assigning Tasks to Class Groups

Teachers or class leaders divide the class into small groups to complete tasks together. Good task assignment makes the work fair and effective.

- **Form groups of 4 to 6.** Mix students with different strengths.
- **Give a clear task:** state the topic, the output (report, chart, presentation, role play) and the deadline.
- **Set rules and time limits.**
- **Assign roles inside the group:** leader (guides), speaker (presents), note-taker (records), timekeeper (watches the time) and researcher (finds information).
- **Rotate roles** in later tasks so that everyone practises every skill.
- **Check progress** and give feedback.

Role	Responsibility
Leader	Guides the discussion, keeps the group on task, ensures every member speaks
Speaker / spokesperson	Presents the group's result to the class
Note-taker / recorder	Writes down ideas and decisions
Timekeeper	Makes sure each step finishes on time
Researcher	Collects facts and references

3. Appointing Group Leaders to Communicate

A **group leader** represents the group and makes sure communication flows within the group and between the group and the teacher or class.

Qualities of a good group leader

- Good communicator and listener.
- Fair and unbiased; treats all members with respect.
- Calm in problems; able to solve conflicts.
- Motivates others and shares credit.
- Organised and responsible; keeps the group on time.

How leaders can be appointed

- The teacher nominates a leader, or the group chooses one by agreement or vote.
- Leadership may rotate so that each member gets a chance.

What the leader does in communication

- Explains the task to all members in clear words and checks understanding.
- Invites ideas from everyone and summarises discussions.
- Reports progress and problems to the teacher.
- Presents or chooses a spokesperson for the final presentation.

4. Completion of Tasks Based on Communication

A group completes its task successfully only when its members communicate well. Communication connects planning, action and feedback.

Step	Communication needed
1. Understand the task	Ask questions and clear doubts; repeat the task in your own words
2. Plan	Brainstorm ideas; discuss and agree on a plan and timeline
3. Divide the work	Match jobs to members' strengths; state who does what by when
4. Carry out the work	Share updates regularly; ask for help when stuck
5. Combine the results	Review each part together; remove repetitions and gaps
6. Present and evaluate	Give and receive feedback; learn for the next task

Barriers: unclear instructions, unequal participation, ego clashes, and lack of listening. **Solutions:** regular meetings, clear roles, written notes of decisions and respectful discussion.

5. Group Cohesion Through Communication

Group cohesion is the feeling of unity, trust and commitment that holds a group together. A cohesive group works better, enjoys the work and handles conflict well. Communication builds cohesion in these ways:

- **Openness and honesty:** members share ideas and worries without fear.
- **Active listening:** every member feels heard and valued.
- **Shared goals:** everyone knows and agrees on the purpose of the group.
- **Appreciation:** recognise each member's contribution: 'That was a great idea, Meena.'
- **Constructive feedback:** criticise the idea, not the person.
- **Conflict resolution:** discuss disagreements calmly and look for a solution that works for everyone.
- **Team activities and informal talk** also strengthen bonds.

When communication is poor, misunderstandings, rumours, conflicts and low motivation follow, and the group may fall apart.

6. Group Presentations

In a group presentation, several members present one topic together. It tests both individual speaking and teamwork.

Steps

- **Choose and understand the topic;** decide the key message.
- **Research and divide** the topic into parts; each member takes one part.
- **Structure:** Introduction (topic and outline) - Main body (the parts in a logical order) - Conclusion (summary and final message) - Question and answer.
- **Prepare visuals** together so that the slides look consistent.
- **Rehearse** as a group to fix the timing and the transitions.
- **Deliver:** speak clearly, face the audience, support each other and hand over smoothly: 'Now my colleague Meena will explain...'
- **Handle questions** as a team: the right person answers, and others add when needed.

Tips

- Dress neatly and be on time.
- Do not read from the slides or notes; use keywords.
- Every member should speak for roughly equal time.
- Thank the audience at the end.

7. Use of PowerPoint Presentations

PowerPoint is presentation software used to make slides with text, pictures, charts and videos. Slides support the speaker; they are not a script.

Principles of good slides

Principle	How to apply it
One idea per slide	Keep a clear heading and 3 to 5 short points
Brief text	Use keywords and short phrases, not long sentences or paragraphs
Readable fonts	Body text at least 24 point; headings 32 point or larger; plain fonts such as Arial or Calibri
High contrast	Dark text on a light background, or light text on a dark one
Visuals	Use relevant pictures, charts and diagrams; avoid cluttered or low-quality images
Consistent design	Same fonts, colours and layout throughout
Limited effects	Use animation and sound only where it helps

Structure of a slide deck

- **Title slide:** topic, names and date.
- **Outline / agenda:** what will be covered.
- **Content slides:** main points with examples and visuals.
- **Conclusion slide:** key takeaways.
- **Thank-you / Questions slide.**

During the presentation

- Speak to the audience, not to the screen.
- Use the slide as a cue and explain more than what is written.
- Use a pointer or gesture to guide attention.
- Check your equipment and file format before the presentation, and keep a backup copy.

UNIT V - LISTENING SKILLS AND NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

Communication has two sides: sending a message and receiving it. Listening is the skill of receiving spoken messages, and non-verbal communication is the message we send without words. Both are essential for a good speaker.

1. Importance of Listening

Listening takes up a larger share of our communication time than speaking, reading or writing. Yet many people never learn to listen well. **Hearing** is the physical ability to perceive sound; **listening** is the active mental effort to understand its meaning.

Why listening is important

- **Learning:** most classroom information comes through listening.
- **Understanding instructions** correctly and avoiding mistakes.
- **Building relationships:** people trust those who listen to them.
- **Better speaking:** listening to good speakers improves your pronunciation, vocabulary and fluency.
- **Solving problems and avoiding conflict** because you get the full picture.
- **Career success:** managers, teachers, doctors and customer-service staff all rely on listening.

2. Basics of Listening

The listening process

Listening works in five stages: **receiving** (hearing and paying attention), **understanding** (finding meaning), **remembering** (storing the message), **evaluating** (judging the message), and **responding** (giving feedback by words or actions).

Types of listening

Type	Purpose	Example
Appreciative	For enjoyment	Listening to music, a story or a poem
Informational	To learn information	Listening to a lecture or news
Critical (evaluative)	To judge an argument	Listening to a debate or advertisement
Empathetic	To understand feelings and support	Listening to a friend with a problem
Discriminative	To notice differences in sounds	Listening to pronunciation of /ship/ and /sheep/

Active listening: how to do it

- Give full attention: look at the speaker and put away distractions such as your phone.
- Do not interrupt; let the speaker finish.
- Show interest through nods, a pleasant expression and small responses: 'I see', 'Go on'.
- Ask questions to clarify: 'Do you mean that...?'
- Paraphrase to check understanding: 'So you are saying that...'
- Take brief notes of key points when listening to a lecture.
- Do not judge or plan your reply too early.

3. Barriers to Listening

A barrier is anything that blocks the message from reaching the listener or being understood correctly.

Barrier	Examples	How to overcome
Physical	Noise, poor acoustics, a bad phone line, hunger, tiredness	Choose a quiet place, sit near the speaker, rest well
Psychological	Stress, anger, worry, prejudice, fixed opinions, lack of interest	Calm yourself, keep an open mind, focus on the message
Language	Unfamiliar words, technical terms, strong accent, fast speech	Build vocabulary, ask the speaker to repeat or slow down
Attention	Daydreaming, thinking about your reply, using your phone	Concentrate and avoid multitasking
Information overload	Too much information at once	Take notes, ask for breaks
Cultural	Different customs and meanings of gestures	Learn about other cultures; do not assume
Speaker-related	Unclear, disorganised or boring delivery	Listen for the main points; ask questions

4. Listening for Gist, Style and Tone

Gist

The **gist** is the main idea or general meaning of a message. To listen for gist, ignore small details and ask: *What is this mainly about? What is the speaker's main point?* Listen to the opening and closing sentences, repeated ideas and words stressed by the speaker.

Style

Style is the way language is used: formal or informal, simple or technical, spoken or written style, polite or direct. A lecture uses a formal, organised style; a chat between friends uses slang and short forms. Noticing style tells you about the speaker, the audience and the situation.

Tone

Tone is the speaker's attitude or feeling, shown by pitch, speed, volume, stress and pauses. Words such as 'Fine' can sound happy, angry or sarcastic depending on the tone.

Tone	How it sounds	Example
Cheerful	High pitch, lively pace	'What a wonderful surprise!'
Angry	Loud, sharp, fast	'I told you not to do that!'
Sad	Low, slow, soft	'I miss him so much.'
Sarcastic	Exaggerated stress, flat or mocking voice	'Oh, great. Another Monday.'
Polite / formal	Calm, even, careful words	'Would you kindly help me?'
Neutral	Even, without strong feeling	'The meeting is at five.'

5. Voice Recording Exercises

Recording your own voice and other voices is a simple, effective way to improve listening and speaking.

- **Record yourself** reading a short passage or speaking for one to two minutes on a topic.
- **Play it back** and check pronunciation, stress and intonation, speed, pauses, volume, clarity and filler words.
- **Compare** with a model recording of a good speaker.
- **Repeat** after practice and note the improvement.
- **Listening tasks:** listen to a recorded talk or news item, write its gist in two sentences, then list three details.
- **Dictation:** listen and write down what you hear; then check against the script.
- **Group exercise:** record a conversation or role play and discuss how each speaker sounded.

6. Body Language

Non-verbal communication means sending messages without words, through the body, face, voice and use of space. **Body language** is the part of it that uses the body: gestures, posture, facial expressions, eye movement and touch. Researchers often say that a large share of the impact of a message, especially of feelings and attitudes, comes from non-verbal signals. People trust body language more than words when the two do not match.

Forms of non-verbal communication

Form	Meaning	Example
Kinesics	Body movement: gestures, posture, facial expressions	Nodding, shrugging, smiling
Oculesics	Eye contact and eye movement	Looking at the speaker to show attention
Proxemics	Use of space and distance	Standing close to friends, farther from strangers
Haptics	Touch	A handshake, a pat on the back
Paralanguage	How something is said: pitch, volume, speed, pauses	Speaking softly to comfort
Appearance	Dress, grooming	Formal clothes in an interview
Chronemics	Use of time	Arriving on time shows respect

7. Importance of Body Language in Communication

- **Reinforces** words: nodding while saying 'yes'.
- **Replaces** words: a thumbs-up for 'good'.
- **Contradicts** words: saying 'I'm fine' with a sad face.
- **Regulates** conversation: looking at someone shows it is their turn to speak.
- **Shows feelings** and attitude: confidence, interest, nervousness or boredom.
- **Creates impressions** in interviews, presentations and meetings.
- Make your words and body language **match** so that you sound sincere and credible.

8. Gestures, Posture, Eye Contact and Facial Expressions

Gestures

Gestures are movements of the hands, arms and head. They emphasise points and add interest.

- Use natural, open hand movements at about waist-to-chest level.
- Avoid distracting habits: fidgeting, tapping, playing with a pen or hair, pointing a finger at people.
- Be aware that gestures differ among cultures. For example, a nod means 'yes' in many countries, but a side-to-side head wobble in India can also mean agreement.

Posture

Posture is the way you stand or sit. It shows confidence, energy and respect.

- Stand straight with shoulders relaxed and weight even on both feet.
- Sit upright, slightly forward to show interest; keep feet flat on the floor.
- Avoid slouching, crossing arms tightly (looks defensive), or leaning on walls and tables.
- Keep your hands visible and relaxed, not in pockets.

Eye contact

Eye contact shows honesty, confidence and attention. A speaker who avoids eye contact may seem nervous or dishonest.

- Look at the person for a few seconds at a time, then look away naturally; do not stare.
- In a group or audience, move your gaze across all sections of the room.
- In some cultures, long direct eye contact with elders is considered disrespectful; adjust to the situation.

Facial expressions

The face is the most expressive part of the body. Expressions of happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise and disgust are understood almost everywhere.

- A genuine smile creates warmth and trust.
- Let your expression match your words: serious for serious matters, pleasant for greetings.
- Avoid a blank or frowning face while listening, because it may look like boredom or disapproval.

Body language	Positive signal	Negative signal
Posture	Upright, relaxed	Slouched, stiff
Eye contact	Natural, steady	Avoiding or staring
Hands	Open palms, calm gestures	Fidgeting, clenched fists
Face	Smile, interest	Frown, blank look
Arms	Relaxed at sides	Tightly crossed
Head	Nodding in agreement	Looking away, shaking head repeatedly

9. Etiquette

Etiquette means accepted rules of polite and respectful behaviour in social, academic and professional situations. Good etiquette builds trust and creates a good impression.

General etiquette

- Be **punctual**: arrive on time for classes, meetings and appointments.
- Dress suitably for the occasion; be neat and clean.
- Greet people politely and use 'please', 'thank you', 'excuse me' and 'sorry'.
- Do not interrupt; wait for your turn to speak.
- Show respect to elders, teachers and colleagues, regardless of their position.

- Respect different cultures, languages and beliefs.
- Keep your mobile phone on silent and avoid using it during conversations and meetings.

Telephone etiquette

- Answer promptly; greet and identify yourself: 'Good morning, this is Ravi speaking.'
- Speak clearly, in a pleasant tone and at a moderate speed.
- Listen carefully; do not eat or talk to others while on the call.
- End politely: 'Thank you for calling. Goodbye.'

Meeting and classroom etiquette

- Arrive before the starting time and switch off your phone.
- Raise your hand to speak and stay on topic.
- Listen to others without interruptions.
- Disagree politely and accept feedback gracefully.

Dining and social etiquette

- Wait for the host or elders before starting to eat.
- Do not talk with your mouth full.
- Thank the host.

Recommended Reading

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